



Mostly sunny 57/41 • Tomorrow: Partly sunny 59/40 **B6**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

MONDAY, FEBRUARY 24, 2025 • \$4

Germany's far right surges but stops short

Conservative Christian Democrats claim victory, must build coalition

BY KATE BRADY,
ADAM TAYLOR
AND WILLIAM BOOTH

BERLIN — Veteran politician Friedrich Merz, the leader of Germany's conservative Christian Democrats, claimed victory in the federal election Sunday evening as preliminary returns indicated the party would win a plurality in the Bundestag.

The far right, meanwhile, was projected to make historic gains, and the far left also surged. The country's increasingly fractured politics could complicate the job of forming a coalition to govern.

Merz, Germany's likely next chancellor, warned that the task ahead will not be easy.

"The main thing is to create a functioning government in Germany as quickly as possible with a good parliamentary majority," he told supporters at the Christian Democrats' headquarters in Berlin.

"The world out there is not waiting for us. And it is not waiting for lengthy coalition talks and negotiations. We must now quickly become capable of acting again so that we can do the right thing at home, so that we are present in Europe again, so that the world sees that Germany will govern reliably again."

The government will be expected to take on the country's most pressing challenges: boosting its stagnating economy and deficient infrastructure, and reassessing its role in the shifting global order. Migration also

SEE GERMANY ON A11

Trump turns back to an older world order

President is spurning post-WWII system built to check aggressors

BY MICHAEL BIRNBAUM

In his first month in office, President Donald Trump has upended the nation's nearly century-old approach to global affairs.

The speed and energy with which the president has moved to remake Washington's role in the world has been most visible in his approach to the war between Russia and Ukraine. He has embraced Russia's strength and blasted the smaller country, falsely accusing President Volodymyr Zelensky of starting a conflict that began with a Russian invasion. He has insulted U.S. allies in Europe, who for decades have relied on the United States to check Russian power.

The result, diplomats and analysts say, has been to cede influence to Moscow. But that might just be the beginning. At worst, Trump's strategy could embolden other global powers, notably China, to adopt more bellicose policies toward their neighbors, they say — the opposite of what some

SEE TRUMP ON A8

Faithful pray for pope's recovery as he remains in hospital



EMILIANO LASALVIA/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

A woman touches a painting of Pope Francis at the Basilica San José de Flores in Buenos Aires on Sunday. The 88-year-old pontiff remained hospitalized a day after his condition had been listed as "critical." **Story, A11**

Weight-loss drugs could reshape economy, too

BY ARIANA EUNJUNG CHA

Chicago trial attorney John Drews, like many well-employed Americans, has always given himself a generous discretionary spending budget. As a divorced empty-nester, his purchase priorities, in no particular order, included Scotch, chocolates, pretzels, eating out and beach resorts. Then, in May 2022, following reports by celebrities and influencers about blockbuster weight-loss drugs, he decided to go on one himself, and everything changed.

He lost 25 pounds the first year, then 75 pounds more the following year. Afterward, Drews says, he didn't just feel like a different person. He basically was one —

Analysts are taking note of users' changes in discretionary spending

with food, clothing, workout and vacation habits that have almost completely overridden everything he used to spend his money on, to the tune of more than \$100,000 annually.

"It's a whole new life," Drews said.

He is just one consumer. But multiply his experience by the roughly 16 million people — that's 6 percent of American adults — taking GLP-1 weight-loss drugs, and their collective purchasing

power has the potential to profoundly reshape the economy in the coming years.

There's evidence that the demographic of people on the drugs overlaps with those who like to spend, a group some analysts have dubbed "over consumers." Cutting their daily calorie counts in half — or more — is resulting in all sorts of interesting consequences still coming to light.

Ozempic, and its GLP-1 cousins Mounjaro, Wegovy and Zepbound, may not be the lightbulb, jet airplane or internet, but their impact is expected to be so significant that Jan Hatzius, chief economist at Goldman Sachs, predicts that if 60 million people take the medications by 2028, GDP would be boosted by 1 percent — or

several trillion dollars. Hatzius's analysis was based primarily on the idea that healthier people mean a healthier workforce and, in turn, lower health-care costs.

But there's a lot more to it. "When we think about how the drugs work, it directly changes the purchase of foods. But then there are spillover effects on a lot of sectors," said Aljoscha Janssen, an assistant professor of economics at Singapore Management University who is studying spending by U.S. consumers who are diabetic or overweight.

A study by Cornell University and Numerator shows that GLP-1 users are spending less at coffee shops and fast-food chains. PricewaterhouseCoopers sees upsides

SEE OZEMPIC ON A6

Crematory leaves some awaiting ashes, answers

A Md. facility contracted by D.C. for cremations continued to operate despite years of red flags

BY MARISSA J. LANG,
KATIE METTLER
AND KATIE SHEPHERD

Her father's ashes had been sitting in the family home for two weeks when her phone rang.

Emily Hooper answered, confused why the company that cremated her dad would be calling now, nearly a month after his death.

A woman, she recalled, introduced herself as an employee from Heaven Bound Cremation Services in Maryland. She was calling to tell Hooper, 25, that the remains of her father, Donald Hooper Jr., 56, had been taken to a state facility.

Hooper's head spun. She thought of her father: a former Calvert County sheriff's deputy who took her hunting for deer and cared deeply about his K-9 partner, a German shepherd named Hassan. Then she thought of the ashes in her stepmother's home.

If those weren't her father's — whose were they?

She tried to ask, she said, but

SEE REMAINS ON A4



ASTRID RIECKEN/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Rachelle Ellison hands out balloons at a memorial service in D.C. for her friend Charles Evans last month. She said she won't stop calling the city until she learns when Evans can be cremated.

Officials' advice differs on email

SOME LEADERS WARY OF MUSK REQUEST

Many workers told not to reply to mass missive

BY DAN ROSENZWEIG-ZIFF,
HANNAH NATANSON
AND CAROL D. LEONNIG

Elon Musk's demand that all 2.3 million government workers justify their work prompted confusion and resistance on Sunday, as several government agency leaders told their staffs not to reply to a mass email requesting bullet-point summations of their accomplishments.

Director of National Intelligence Tulsi Gabbard instructed personnel in U.S. spy agencies not to respond, according to the text of an email she sent to the workforce on Sunday, citing the agencies' sensitive and classified work. Defense Department employees were given similar instructions to not respond, as were FBI personnel and Department of Homeland Security employees.

The latest directives come as employees and leaders alike across the government were caught off guard by an email sent Saturday titled: "What did you do last week?"

It commanded federal employees to "reply to this email with approx. 5 bullets of what you accomplished last week and cc your manager," according to a copy obtained by The Washington Post. It gave employees a deadline of 11:59 p.m. Eastern time Monday.

SEE DOGE ON A5

Proposed tariffs roil car-centric Mich. town

Some see industry's salvation in Trump's actions, others disaster

BY CLEVE R. WOOTSON JR.

STERLING HEIGHTS, MICH. — Michael Taylor, the mayor of this auto-industry-dominated city north of Detroit, has had more conversations than he can count with nervous neighbors and alarmed industry leaders about President Donald Trump's tariff plans, which Taylor sees as "the single-biggest threat to our local economy."

"We're still scrambling to figure out what it all means, and it's coming at a breakneck speed," said Taylor, a lifelong Republican who voted against Trump in 2020 and 2024. "If those tariffs go into effect as promised, it would be devastating."

But James Benson, whose job at the Stellantis plant in Sterling Heights is his eighth auto industry job in 25 years, sees the tariffs as a chance to level the global playing field for him and other workers who've seen a parade of politicians unable to stop decades of contraction. A Trump supporter since

SEE AUTOWORKERS ON A2

IN THE NEWS

A mission at risk President Donald Trump's moves to slash the federal workforce and spending have struck a nerve in the Pentagon's POW/MIA recovery office. **A3**

Nasrallah's funeral Hezbollah formally buried its slain leader in a long-awaited ceremony that drew tens of thousands. **A10**

THE NATION
Laredo, Texas, and Nuevo Laredo, Mexico, threw a party in honor of George Washington. **A9**
The Trump administration said in notices that it will eliminate 1,600 jobs at USAID. **A13**

THE WORLD
Ukraine's Volodymyr Zelensky called for a meeting with Trump. **A11**
Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu demanded the "complete demilitarization" of southern Syria. **A11**

THE ECONOMY
Shira Ovide explains how California is leading the way among U.S. states in protecting people's online privacy. **A13**

THE REGION
Montgomery County schools may decide this spring whether to ban cellphone use by all students during the day. **B1**

A lawsuit alleges the District's only psychiatric hospital systematically commits patients when not medically necessary to maximize insurance payments. **B1**
Drug test failures, mostly for cannabis use, are fueling a shortage of school crossing guards in D.C., officials said. **B1**

STYLE
"Beyond the Gates," premiering on CBS, is the first daytime serial centered on a Black family in the history of U.S. broadcast television. **C1**
As Kennedy Center ticket sales drop, artists are weighing whether to cancel shows in protest of Trump's takeover. **C1**

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